

## **Canonical murder facts**

Grant Larceny dies from a botanical cardiac toxin applied inside his silver coupe and on its rim using toxin-dampened gold-seamed linen. The glass was clean at 6:40; he drank at 6:49. One attending guest is selected through the memorized animal draw. Every role has a working murderer branch. Only the murderer matches all three: salon entry after 6:40, cabinet key loan during setup and gold-seamed linen possession. No keys, samples or linen changed hands.

All questions, answers, preparation records, the ballot and both Coming Clean statements are in each fourteen-page packet. No separate letter cards, question catalog or finale envelope. Coming Clean is the final page and remains unread until all votes are locked. The top three suspects read their appropriate statements; if none confesses, call the murderer animal to stand and confess.

## **Artie Ficial**

Victim relationship: Grant had privately informed you that tonight's gift would come with a new governance agreement: he wanted veto power over acquisitions, his name on the museum, and your resignation within sixty days. You smiled through the meeting and told no one.

Hidden complication: You have already accepted a confidential offer to lead a rival museum next year, which makes any argument with Grant look like succession planning.

Innocent route: I went into the Donor Salon at 6:36, correcting Grant's speech cards. I did not go back after that. I borrowed the cabinet key during setup to inspect the podium polish stored inside. I carried a white linen cloth with a gold seam, for rescuing a champagne-spotted gala program. That was what the materials desk issued me. You did not poison Grant.

Murderer route: During setup you borrowed the controlled cabinet key and took the toxin sample. At 6:47 you entered the Donor Salon, correcting Grant's speech cards. You dampened your issued gold-seamed linen with the

stolen sample and wiped the inside of Grant's coupe and its rim, transferring the toxin. You left with the cloth. You acted alone.

Innocent Coming Clean: I accepted an offer from a rival museum. I was protecting my next job, not plotting a murder. My recorded salon visit ended before 6:40 and I did not return. The coupe was still clean at 6:40; I was not inside during the poisoning window. I had something to hide, but I did not murder Grant Larceny.

Murderer Coming Clean: Grant wanted veto power over acquisitions, his name on the museum and my resignation within sixty days. He called that a gift. I called it a takeover. I had not agreed to surrender my museum or my job. During setup I borrowed the cabinet key and took the toxin sample. At 6:47, I used the excuse of correcting Grant's speech cards to enter the salon. I dampened my gold-seamed linen with the sample and wiped the inside of Grant's coupe and its rim. That transferred the poison. I left with the cloth. The door entry, key loan and linen receipt were all real. What I left out was what I did between them.

Innocent preparation record: MERIDIAN / PREPARATION RECORD Salon door register: 6:36; no later entry. Conservation key book: loan at 6:00, returned and cabinet relocked. Materials inventory, 6:39: white linen cloth, gold seam. Purpose noted by guest: correcting Grant's speech cards; rescuing a champagne-spotted gala program. These are the original preparation records for Artie Ficial.

Murderer preparation record: MERIDIAN / PREPARATION RECORD Salon door register: 6:47. Conservation key book: loan at 6:00, returned and cabinet relocked. Materials inventory, 6:39: white linen cloth, gold seam. Purpose noted by guest: correcting Grant's speech cards; rescuing a champagne-spotted gala program. These are the original preparation records for Artie Ficial.

## Claire O'Scuro

**Victim relationship:** You discovered that Grant knew the Star Bowl's provenance file contained a major gap and ordered the exhibition to proceed anyway. He threatened to remove you from the show if you raised the issue publicly.

**Hidden complication:** Against board instructions, you commissioned an independent provenance review and hid the preliminary report in the Registrar's Office.

**Innocent route:** I went into the Donor Salon at 6:44, correcting the Star Bowl label. I visited the conservation display, checking the display cleaning instructions, but did not borrow the cabinet key. I carried a white linen cloth with a gold seam, for dusting the edge of a display mount. That was what the materials desk issued me. You did not poison Grant.

**Murderer route:** During setup you borrowed the controlled cabinet key and took the toxin sample. At 6:44 you entered the Donor Salon, correcting the Star Bowl label. You dampened your issued gold-seamed linen with the stolen sample and wiped the inside of Grant's coupe and its rim, transferring the toxin. You left with the cloth. You acted alone.

**Innocent Coming Clean:** I commissioned the independent provenance review and hid its preliminary report. I wanted the truth checked before anyone buried it. The key book confirms I never borrowed the cabinet key. The cabinet stayed locked between logged loans, and no key or sample changed hands. I had no access to the toxin. I had something to hide, but I did not murder Grant Larceny.

**Murderer Coming Clean:** The Star Bowl's provenance file had a major gap, and Grant knew it. He wanted the show to proceed with my approval anyway. When I objected, he threatened to remove me from the exhibition. My name is not a certificate of convenience. During setup I borrowed the cabinet key and took the toxin sample. At 6:44, I used the excuse of correcting the Star Bowl label to enter the salon. I dampened my gold-seamed linen with the sample and wiped the inside of Grant's coupe and its rim. That transferred the poison. I left with the cloth. The door entry,

key loan and linen receipt were all real. What I left out was what I did between them.

Innocent preparation record: MERIDIAN / PREPARATION RECORD Salon door register: 6:44. Conservation key book: no key loan. Materials inventory, 6:39: white linen cloth, gold seam. Purpose noted by guest: correcting the Star Bowl label; dusting the edge of a display mount. These are the original preparation records for Claire O'Scuro.

Murderer preparation record: MERIDIAN / PREPARATION RECORD Salon door register: 6:44. Conservation key book: loan at 6:01, returned and cabinet relocked. Materials inventory, 6:39: white linen cloth, gold seam. Purpose noted by guest: correcting the Star Bowl label; dusting the edge of a display mount. These are the original preparation records for Claire O'Scuro.

## **Hugh Bidder**

Victim relationship: Grant had learned that one certificate in a major private sale you brokered was forged before it ever reached you. He planned to imply publicly that you had created it unless you refunded him millions.

Hidden complication: You were duped on that sale, but you quietly altered your own file afterward so clients would not see how badly your due diligence failed.

Innocent route: I went into the Donor Salon at 6:46, delivering a revised appraisal. I borrowed the cabinet key during setup to inspect the replica-decanter treatment sheet stored inside. I carried blue disposable paper wipes, for polishing a replica decanter for photographs. That was what the materials desk issued me. You did not poison Grant.

Murderer route: During setup you borrowed the controlled cabinet key and took the toxin sample. At 6:46 you entered the Donor Salon, delivering a revised appraisal. You dampened your issued gold-seamed linen with the stolen sample and wiped the inside of Grant's coupe and its rim, transferring the toxin. You left with the cloth. You acted alone.

Innocent Coming Clean: I altered my file after being duped on that sale. My due diligence failed, and I tried to hide the embarrassment. The materials desk issued me blue paper wipes, not gold-seamed linen. The poisoned smear contains the gold thread from a cloth; the paper I carried cannot have left it. I had something to hide, but I did not murder Grant Larceny.

Murderer Coming Clean: A sale certificate was forged before it reached me. Grant knew that, but he planned to blame me unless I refunded millions. I did not forge it. I did alter my file afterward to hide how badly my checks had failed. During setup I borrowed the cabinet key and took the toxin sample. At 6:46, I used the excuse of delivering a revised appraisal to enter the salon. I dampened my gold-seamed linen with the sample and wiped the inside of Grant's coupe and its rim. That transferred the poison. I left with the cloth. The door entry, key loan and linen receipt were all real. What I left out was what I did between them.

Innocent preparation record: MERIDIAN / PREPARATION RECORD Salon door register: 6:46. Conservation key book: loan at 6:02, returned and cabinet relocked. Materials inventory, 6:39: blue disposable paper wipes. Purpose noted by guest: delivering a revised appraisal; polishing a replica decanter for photographs. These are the original preparation records for Hugh Bidder.

Murderer preparation record: MERIDIAN / PREPARATION RECORD Salon door register: 6:46. Conservation key book: loan at 6:02, returned and cabinet relocked. Materials inventory, 6:39: white linen cloth, gold seam. Purpose noted by guest: delivering a revised appraisal; polishing a replica decanter for photographs. These are the original preparation records for Hugh Bidder.

## Monet Bags

Victim relationship: Grant demanded that you disguise several gala and naming-wing expenses inside restricted museum funds until his promised donation cleared. When you resisted, he threatened to blame the bookkeeping on you.

Hidden complication: You temporarily moved money between internal accounts to cover a cash-flow shortfall, intending to reverse it after the gala. It was technically unauthorized and Grant discovered it.

Innocent route: I went into the Donor Salon at 6:36, getting his approval on an expense sheet. I did not go back after that. I borrowed the cabinet key during setup to inspect the insured-stock list stored inside. I carried a white linen cloth with a gold seam, for drying a splash on my expense folder. That was what the materials desk issued me. You did not poison Grant.

Murderer route: During setup you borrowed the controlled cabinet key and took the toxin sample. At 6:45 you entered the Donor Salon, getting his approval on an expense sheet. You dampened your issued gold-seamed linen with the stolen sample and wiped the inside of Grant's coupe and its rim, transferring the toxin. You left with the cloth. You acted alone.

Innocent Coming Clean: I moved money between accounts without authorization. I meant to reverse it after the gala. That was a financial mistake I must answer for. My recorded salon visit ended before 6:40 and I did not return. The coupe was still clean at 6:40; I was not inside during the poisoning window. I had something to hide, but I did not murder Grant Larceny.

Murderer Coming Clean: Grant wanted gala and naming-wing expenses hidden in restricted museum funds until his donation cleared. I refused. He threatened to blame my bookkeeping. Apparently his generous gift came with instructions for where to bury the bill. During setup I borrowed the cabinet key and took the toxin sample. At 6:45, I used the excuse of getting his approval on an expense sheet to enter the salon. I dampened my gold-seamed linen with the sample and wiped the inside of Grant's coupe and its rim. That transferred the poison. I left with the cloth. The door entry, key loan and linen receipt were all real. What I left out was what I did between them.

Innocent preparation record: MERIDIAN / PREPARATION RECORD Salon door register: 6:36; no later entry. Conservation key book: loan at 6:03, returned and cabinet relocked. Materials inventory, 6:39: white linen cloth, gold seam. Purpose noted by guest: getting his approval on an expense

sheet; drying a splash on my expense folder. These are the original preparation records for Monet Bags.

Murderer preparation record: MERIDIAN / PREPARATION RECORD Salon door register: 6:45. Conservation key book: loan at 6:03, returned and cabinet relocked. Materials inventory, 6:39: white linen cloth, gold seam. Purpose noted by guest: getting his approval on an expense sheet; drying a splash on my expense folder. These are the original preparation records for Monet Bags.

## **Chip Patina**

Victim relationship: Grant pressured you to soften a conservation report showing that one supposedly untouched object had been recently altered. He threatened to replace you with a private conservator if you refused.

Hidden complication: You changed the date on a minor treatment record last month to spare the museum an embarrassing insurance dispute. No object was harmed, but the falsification could end your career.

Innocent route: I went into the Donor Salon at 6:43, explaining the condition report. I visited the conservation display, checking the conservation stock, but did not borrow the cabinet key. I carried a white linen cloth with a gold seam, for cleaning a display tool after setup. That was what the materials desk issued me. You did not poison Grant.

Murderer route: During setup you borrowed the controlled cabinet key and took the toxin sample. At 6:43 you entered the Donor Salon, explaining the condition report. You dampened your issued gold-seamed linen with the stolen sample and wiped the inside of Grant's coupe and its rim, transferring the toxin. You left with the cloth. You acted alone.

Innocent Coming Clean: I changed the date on a treatment record to avoid an insurance dispute. The object was unharmed, but the record was dishonest. The key book confirms I never borrowed the cabinet key. The cabinet stayed locked between logged loans, and no key or sample changed hands. I had no access to the toxin. I had something to hide, but I did not murder Grant Larceny.

**Murderer Coming Clean:** My report showed that a supposedly untouched object had been altered recently. Grant wanted that softened. He threatened to replace me with a private conservator. I preserve objects; I am not employed to preserve his version of events. During setup I borrowed the cabinet key and took the toxin sample. At 6:43, I used the excuse of explaining the condition report to enter the salon. I dampened my gold-seamed linen with the sample and wiped the inside of Grant's coupe and its rim. That transferred the poison. I left with the cloth. The door entry, key loan and linen receipt were all real. What I left out was what I did between them.

**Innocent preparation record:** MERIDIAN / PREPARATION RECORD Salon door register: 6:43. Conservation key book: no key loan. Materials inventory, 6:39: white linen cloth, gold seam. Purpose noted by guest: explaining the condition report; cleaning a display tool after setup. These are the original preparation records for Chip Patina.

**Murderer preparation record:** MERIDIAN / PREPARATION RECORD Salon door register: 6:43. Conservation key book: loan at 6:04, returned and cabinet relocked. Materials inventory, 6:39: white linen cloth, gold seam. Purpose noted by guest: explaining the condition report; cleaning a display tool after setup. These are the original preparation records for Chip Patina.

## Dada DiCapo

**Victim relationship:** Grant appropriated the concept for one of your unreleased performances and planned to unveil a sanitized version of it as the gala's closing spectacle, crediting himself as creative patron.

**Hidden complication:** You wrote and planted the ominous anonymous warning note about 'returning what was taken.' It was meant as an art-world provocation, not a literal threat.

**Innocent route:** I went into the Donor Salon at 6:42, showing him the performance sketch. I borrowed the cabinet key during setup to inspect the removable stage adhesive stored inside. I carried blue disposable paper wipes, for wiping a rehearsal prop. That was what the materials desk issued me. You did not poison Grant.

**Murderer route:** During setup you borrowed the controlled cabinet key and took the toxin sample. At 6:42 you entered the Donor Salon, showing him the performance sketch. You dampened your issued gold-seamed linen with the stolen sample and wiped the inside of Grant's coupe and its rim, transferring the toxin. You left with the cloth. You acted alone.

**Innocent Coming Clean:** I planted the anonymous warning note. It was a provocation about stolen art, not a plan to kill anyone. The materials desk issued me blue paper wipes, not gold-seamed linen. The poisoned smear contains the gold thread from a cloth; the paper I carried cannot have left it. I had something to hide, but I did not murder Grant Larceny.

**Murderer Coming Clean:** That closing spectacle was my unreleased performance concept. Grant took it, sanitized it and planned to unveil it with himself credited as creative patron. He bought the invitation stock, not my imagination. I wanted my work and my credit back. During setup I borrowed the cabinet key and took the toxin sample. At 6:42, I used the excuse of showing him the performance sketch to enter the salon. I dampened my gold-seamed linen with the sample and wiped the inside of Grant's coupe and its rim. That transferred the poison. I left with the cloth. The door entry, key loan and linen receipt were all real. What I left out was what I did between them.

**Innocent preparation record:** MERIDIAN / PREPARATION RECORD Salon door register: 6:42. Conservation key book: loan at 6:05, returned and cabinet relocked. Materials inventory, 6:39: blue disposable paper wipes. Purpose noted by guest: showing him the performance sketch; wiping a rehearsal prop. These are the original preparation records for Dada DiCapo.

**Murderer preparation record:** MERIDIAN / PREPARATION RECORD Salon door register: 6:42. Conservation key book: loan at 6:05, returned and cabinet relocked. Materials inventory, 6:39: white linen cloth, gold seam. Purpose noted by guest: showing him the performance sketch; wiping a rehearsal prop. These are the original preparation records for Dada DiCapo.

## Vincent Van Faux

Victim relationship: Grant owned an embarrassing student painting you have spent years trying to buy back. He planned to display it tonight beside your celebrated recent work as a joke about 'humble beginnings.'

Hidden complication: You have secretly used buyers to acquire several of your own early paintings so you could remove them from circulation. The art world would find that both vain and market-manipulative.

Innocent route: I went into the Donor Salon at 6:36, asking him to withdraw the student painting. I did not go back after that. I borrowed the cabinet key during setup to inspect the varnish sample stored inside. I carried a white linen cloth with a gold seam, for cleaning a smear from my painting easel. That was what the materials desk issued me. You did not poison Grant.

Murderer route: During setup you borrowed the controlled cabinet key and took the toxin sample. At 6:44 you entered the Donor Salon, asking him to withdraw the student painting. You dampened your issued gold-seamed linen with the stolen sample and wiped the inside of Grant's coupe and its rim, transferring the toxin. You left with the cloth. You acted alone.

Innocent Coming Clean: I used buyers to recover my own early paintings. I wanted those student works out of circulation. Vanity is an excellent motive for secrecy. My recorded salon visit ended before 6:40 and I did not return. The coupe was still clean at 6:40; I was not inside during the poisoning window. I had something to hide, but I did not murder Grant Larceny.

Murderer Coming Clean: Grant owned a student painting I have spent years trying to buy back. Tonight he wanted it beside my celebrated work as a joke about humble beginnings. I did not consent to being the punchline of my own exhibition. During setup I borrowed the cabinet key and took the toxin sample. At 6:44, I used the excuse of asking him to withdraw the student painting to enter the salon. I dampened my gold-seamed linen with the sample and wiped the inside of Grant's coupe and its rim. That transferred the poison. I left with the cloth. The door entry, key loan and linen receipt were all real. What I left out was what I did between them.

Innocent preparation record: MERIDIAN / PREPARATION RECORD Salon door register: 6:36; no later entry. Conservation key book: loan at 6:06, returned and cabinet relocked. Materials inventory, 6:39: white linen cloth, gold seam. Purpose noted by guest: asking him to withdraw the student painting; cleaning a smear from my painting easel. These are the original preparation records for Vincent Van Faux.

Murderer preparation record: MERIDIAN / PREPARATION RECORD Salon door register: 6:44. Conservation key book: loan at 6:06, returned and cabinet relocked. Materials inventory, 6:39: white linen cloth, gold seam. Purpose noted by guest: asking him to withdraw the student painting; cleaning a smear from my painting easel. These are the original preparation records for Vincent Van Faux.

## Sue Venir

Victim relationship: You wrote a private legal memorandum concluding that the Star Bowl's acquisition was too risky to defend confidently. Grant forced you to replace it with a softer opinion and planned to cite your name during the announcement.

Hidden complication: Both versions of the memo still exist. You kept the original instead of destroying it, which could expose you to professional embarrassment and Grant to serious scrutiny.

Innocent route: I went into the Donor Salon at 6:46, delivering the donor agreement. I visited the conservation display, reading the hazardous-materials notice, but did not borrow the cabinet key. I carried a white linen cloth with a gold seam, for drying a splash on the agreement folder. That was what the materials desk issued me. You did not poison Grant.

Murderer route: During setup you borrowed the controlled cabinet key and took the toxin sample. At 6:46 you entered the Donor Salon, delivering the donor agreement. You dampened your issued gold-seamed linen with the stolen sample and wiped the inside of Grant's coupe and its rim, transferring the toxin. You left with the cloth. You acted alone.

**Innocent Coming Clean:** I kept both versions of my legal memo. The softer version embarrassed me; destroying the original would have been worse. The key book confirms I never borrowed the cabinet key. The cabinet stayed locked between logged loans, and no key or sample changed hands. I had no access to the toxin. I had something to hide, but I did not murder Grant Larceny.

**Murderer Coming Clean:** My original memo said the Star Bowl acquisition was too risky to defend confidently. Grant forced me to replace it with a softer opinion and intended to cite my name tonight. He wanted my signature to do the work his paperwork could not. During setup I borrowed the cabinet key and took the toxin sample. At 6:46, I used the excuse of delivering the donor agreement to enter the salon. I dampened my gold-seamed linen with the sample and wiped the inside of Grant's coupe and its rim. That transferred the poison. I left with the cloth. The door entry, key loan and linen receipt were all real. What I left out was what I did between them.

**Innocent preparation record:** MERIDIAN / PREPARATION RECORD Salon door register: 6:46. Conservation key book: no key loan. Materials inventory, 6:39: white linen cloth, gold seam. Purpose noted by guest: delivering the donor agreement; drying a splash on the agreement folder. These are the original preparation records for Sue Venir.

**Murderer preparation record:** MERIDIAN / PREPARATION RECORD Salon door register: 6:46. Conservation key book: loan at 6:07, returned and cabinet relocked. Materials inventory, 6:39: white linen cloth, gold seam. Purpose noted by guest: delivering the donor agreement; drying a splash on the agreement folder. These are the original preparation records for Sue Venir.

## Dr. Art E. Fact

**Victim relationship:** Grant suppressed your research showing that two objects in his collection passed through a dealer linked to questionable wartime sales. He threatened to release correspondence suggesting you had overstated another provenance claim if you challenged him publicly.

Hidden complication: One celebrated article of yours does contain an inference you stated too confidently. The main thesis still stands, but the mistake would be humiliating.

Innocent route: I went into the Donor Salon at 6:45, showing him the disputed accession page. I borrowed the cabinet key during setup to inspect the reference specimen stored inside. I carried blue disposable paper wipes, for dusting an archival display stand. That was what the materials desk issued me. You did not poison Grant.

Murderer route: During setup you borrowed the controlled cabinet key and took the toxin sample. At 6:45 you entered the Donor Salon, showing him the disputed accession page. You dampened your issued gold-seamed linen with the stolen sample and wiped the inside of Grant's coupe and its rim, transferring the toxin. You left with the cloth. You acted alone.

Innocent Coming Clean: One inference in my famous article was too confident. I will correct it. I was defending my reputation, not poisoning a donor. The materials desk issued me blue paper wipes, not gold-seamed linen. The poisoned smear contains the gold thread from a cloth; the paper I carried cannot have left it. I had something to hide, but I did not murder Grant Larceny.

Murderer Coming Clean: My research linked two collection objects to a dealer involved in questionable wartime sales. Grant suppressed it. He also threatened to release correspondence suggesting I had overstated a different claim. He wanted silence, and he had chosen a very effective threat. During setup I borrowed the cabinet key and took the toxin sample. At 6:45, I used the excuse of showing him the disputed accession page to enter the salon. I dampened my gold-seamed linen with the sample and wiped the inside of Grant's coupe and its rim. That transferred the poison. I left with the cloth. The door entry, key loan and linen receipt were all real. What I left out was what I did between them.

Innocent preparation record: MERIDIAN / PREPARATION RECORD Salon door register: 6:45. Conservation key book: loan at 6:08, returned and cabinet relocked. Materials inventory, 6:39: blue disposable paper wipes. Purpose noted by guest: showing him the disputed accession page; dusting

an archival display stand. These are the original preparation records for Dr. Art E. Fact.

Murderer preparation record: MERIDIAN / PREPARATION RECORD Salon door register: 6:45. Conservation key book: loan at 6:08, returned and cabinet relocked. Materials inventory, 6:39: white linen cloth, gold seam. Purpose noted by guest: showing him the disputed accession page; dusting an archival display stand. These are the original preparation records for Dr. Art E. Fact.

## **Tess Tament**

Victim relationship: Grant told you he intended to rewrite the family trust tonight, removing you from control of the charitable foundation unless you publicly backed his museum naming plan.

Hidden complication: You have been quietly organizing other family trustees to block Grant's control over the foundation and redirect future giving toward worker and community programs.

Innocent route: I went into the Donor Salon at 6:36, discussing the family trust. I did not go back after that. I borrowed the cabinet key during setup to inspect the foundation's donated treatment samples stored inside. I carried a white linen cloth with a gold seam, for wiping cordial off the edge of my folder. That was what the materials desk issued me. You did not poison Grant.

Murderer route: During setup you borrowed the controlled cabinet key and took the toxin sample. At 6:43 you entered the Donor Salon, discussing the family trust. You dampened your issued gold-seamed linen with the stolen sample and wiped the inside of Grant's coupe and its rim, transferring the toxin. You left with the cloth. You acted alone.

Innocent Coming Clean: I organized trustees against Grant's plan. I wanted our foundation funding workers and communities, not his vanity projects. My recorded salon visit ended before 6:40 and I did not return. The coupe was still clean at 6:40; I was not inside during the poisoning window. I had something to hide, but I did not murder Grant Larceny.

**Murderer Coming Clean:** Grant intended to rewrite the family trust tonight. Unless I backed his museum naming plan in public, I would lose control of the charitable foundation. He called it protecting the family. It felt rather more like purchasing my applause. During setup I borrowed the cabinet key and took the toxin sample. At 6:43, I used the excuse of discussing the family trust to enter the salon. I dampened my gold-seamed linen with the sample and wiped the inside of Grant's coupe and its rim. That transferred the poison. I left with the cloth. The door entry, key loan and linen receipt were all real. What I left out was what I did between them.

**Innocent preparation record:** MERIDIAN / PREPARATION RECORD Salon door register: 6:36; no later entry. Conservation key book: loan at 6:09, returned and cabinet relocked. Materials inventory, 6:39: white linen cloth, gold seam. Purpose noted by guest: discussing the family trust; wiping cordial off the edge of my folder. These are the original preparation records for Tess Tament.

**Murderer preparation record:** MERIDIAN / PREPARATION RECORD Salon door register: 6:43. Conservation key book: loan at 6:09, returned and cabinet relocked. Materials inventory, 6:39: white linen cloth, gold seam. Purpose noted by guest: discussing the family trust; wiping cordial off the edge of my folder. These are the original preparation records for Tess Tament.

## Barb Dwyer

**Victim relationship:** Grant ordered you to disable the Donor Salon camera because he planned several off-the-record meetings. He then told you that if anything went wrong tonight, security would 'own the failure.'

**Hidden complication:** You personally unplugged the camera despite museum policy. The work order records the disconnection, but you never documented Grant's threat to make security take the blame.

**Innocent route:** I went into the Donor Salon at 6:41, checking the camera work order. I visited the conservation display, testing the cabinet lock, but did not borrow the cabinet key. I carried a white linen cloth with a gold

seam, for cleaning fingerprints off a security torch. That was what the materials desk issued me. You did not poison Grant.

Murderer route: During setup you borrowed the controlled cabinet key and took the toxin sample. At 6:41 you entered the Donor Salon, checking the camera work order. You dampened your issued gold-seamed linen with the stolen sample and wiped the inside of Grant's coupe and its rim, transferring the toxin. You left with the cloth. You acted alone.

Innocent Coming Clean: I unplugged the salon camera on Grant's orders. The work order records the disconnection; it does not record his threat to make security take the blame. The camera gap was my bad decision, not proof of murder. The key book confirms I never borrowed the cabinet key. The cabinet stayed locked between logged loans, and no key or sample changed hands. I had no access to the toxin. I had something to hide, but I did not murder Grant Larceny.

Murderer Coming Clean: Grant wanted the salon camera off for private meetings. I followed his order. Then he said security would own any failure tonight. He wanted discretion when it suited him and somebody else's head when it did not. During setup I borrowed the cabinet key and took the toxin sample. At 6:41, I used the excuse of checking the camera work order to enter the salon. I dampened my gold-seamed linen with the sample and wiped the inside of Grant's coupe and its rim. That transferred the poison. I left with the cloth. The door entry, key loan and linen receipt were all real. What I left out was what I did between them.

Innocent preparation record: MERIDIAN / PREPARATION RECORD Salon door register: 6:41. Conservation key book: no key loan. Materials inventory, 6:39: white linen cloth, gold seam. Purpose noted by guest: checking the camera work order; cleaning fingerprints off a security torch. These are the original preparation records for Barb Dwyer.

Murderer preparation record: MERIDIAN / PREPARATION RECORD Salon door register: 6:41. Conservation key book: loan at 6:10, returned and cabinet relocked. Materials inventory, 6:39: white linen cloth, gold seam. Purpose noted by guest: checking the camera work order; cleaning

fingerprints off a security torch. These are the original preparation records for Barb Dwyer.

## **Paige Turner**

**Victim relationship:** You were preparing a major investigation into Grant's collection and labor empire. He discovered enough to threaten an injunction and promised to reveal the identity of one of your confidential museum sources if you published.

**Hidden complication:** You obtained internal documents through a source inside the Meridian. Protecting that source matters more to you than tonight's scoop.

**Innocent route:** I went into the Donor Salon at 6:45, asking about my embargoed story. I borrowed the cabinet key during setup to inspect the chemical warning file stored inside. I carried blue disposable paper wipes, for drying a spill on my notebook cover. That was what the materials desk issued me. You did not poison Grant.

**Murderer route:** During setup you borrowed the controlled cabinet key and took the toxin sample. At 6:45 you entered the Donor Salon, asking about my embargoed story. You dampened your issued gold-seamed linen with the stolen sample and wiped the inside of Grant's coupe and its rim, transferring the toxin. You left with the cloth. You acted alone.

**Innocent Coming Clean:** I took internal documents from a museum source. I kept quiet to protect that person. My investigation was meant to expose Grant alive. The materials desk issued me blue paper wipes, not gold-seamed linen. The poisoned smear contains the gold thread from a cloth; the paper I carried cannot have left it. I had something to hide, but I did not murder Grant Larceny.

**Murderer Coming Clean:** I was preparing an investigation into Grant's collection and labor empire. He threatened an injunction and exposure of a confidential museum source if I published. My reputation mattered, but protecting that source mattered more. He knew precisely where to apply pressure. During setup I borrowed the cabinet key and took the toxin

sample. At 6:45, I used the excuse of asking about my embargoed story to enter the salon. I dampened my gold-seamed linen with the sample and wiped the inside of Grant's coupe and its rim. That transferred the poison. I left with the cloth. The door entry, key loan and linen receipt were all real. What I left out was what I did between them.

Innocent preparation record: MERIDIAN / PREPARATION RECORD Salon door register: 6:45. Conservation key book: loan at 6:11, returned and cabinet relocked. Materials inventory, 6:39: blue disposable paper wipes. Purpose noted by guest: asking about my embargoed story; drying a spill on my notebook cover. These are the original preparation records for Paige Turner.

Murderer preparation record: MERIDIAN / PREPARATION RECORD Salon door register: 6:45. Conservation key book: loan at 6:11, returned and cabinet relocked. Materials inventory, 6:39: white linen cloth, gold seam. Purpose noted by guest: asking about my embargoed story; drying a spill on my notebook cover. These are the original preparation records for Paige Turner.

## Frank Lloyd Wrong

Victim relationship: Grant demanded a dangerous last-minute change to the centerpiece display and threatened to withhold your firm's final payment if you refused. He also planned to blame you publicly for any flaw in the opening-night presentation.

Hidden complication: You signed off on one temporary lighting rig that did not fully meet your own design standard because there was no time to rebuild it before the gala.

Innocent route: I went into the Donor Salon at 6:36, checking the revised display plan. I did not go back after that. I borrowed the cabinet key during setup to inspect the display fasteners stored inside. I carried a white linen cloth with a gold seam, for wiping dust from a display bracket. That was what the materials desk issued me. You did not poison Grant.

**Murderer route:** During setup you borrowed the controlled cabinet key and took the toxin sample. At 6:46 you entered the Donor Salon, checking the revised display plan. You dampened your issued gold-seamed linen with the stolen sample and wiped the inside of Grant's coupe and its rim, transferring the toxin. You left with the cloth. You acted alone.

**Innocent Coming Clean:** I approved a temporary lighting rig below my own standard. I should have rebuilt it rather than pretend the deadline made it acceptable. My recorded salon visit ended before 6:40 and I did not return. The coupe was still clean at 6:40; I was not inside during the poisoning window. I had something to hide, but I did not murder Grant Larceny.

**Murderer Coming Clean:** Grant demanded a dangerous last-minute change to the centerpiece. He threatened to withhold my firm's final payment if I refused, then planned to blame me for any flaw. I would be paid nothing for a disaster bearing my name. During setup I borrowed the cabinet key and took the toxin sample. At 6:46, I used the excuse of checking the revised display plan to enter the salon. I dampened my gold-seamed linen with the sample and wiped the inside of Grant's coupe and its rim. That transferred the poison. I left with the cloth. The door entry, key loan and linen receipt were all real. What I left out was what I did between them.

**Innocent preparation record:** MERIDIAN / PREPARATION RECORD Salon door register: 6:36; no later entry. Conservation key book: loan at 6:12, returned and cabinet relocked. Materials inventory, 6:39: white linen cloth, gold seam. Purpose noted by guest: checking the revised display plan; wiping dust from a display bracket. These are the original preparation records for Frank Lloyd Wrong.

**Murderer preparation record:** MERIDIAN / PREPARATION RECORD Salon door register: 6:46. Conservation key book: loan at 6:12, returned and cabinet relocked. Materials inventory, 6:39: white linen cloth, gold seam. Purpose noted by guest: checking the revised display plan; wiping dust from a display bracket. These are the original preparation records for Frank Lloyd Wrong.

## Mona Lott

Victim relationship: Grant intended to announce that the Star Bowl would become a permanent Meridian holding, undermining months of quiet restitution negotiations and publicly humiliating the international partners you represent.

Hidden complication: You leaked the existence of the restitution talks to selected journalists to pressure Grant, even though the negotiations were supposed to remain confidential.

Innocent route: I went into the Donor Salon at 6:44, delivering the restitution memorandum. I visited the conservation display, reading the object-treatment label, but did not borrow the cabinet key. I carried a white linen cloth with a gold seam, for dusting the travel case for a loan object. That was what the materials desk issued me. You did not poison Grant.

Murderer route: During setup you borrowed the controlled cabinet key and took the toxin sample. At 6:44 you entered the Donor Salon, delivering the restitution memorandum. You dampened your issued gold-seamed linen with the stolen sample and wiped the inside of Grant's coupe and its rim, transferring the toxin. You left with the cloth. You acted alone.

Innocent Coming Clean: I leaked the restitution talks to journalists. I wanted public pressure on Grant. It was a breach of confidence, not a death threat. The key book confirms I never borrowed the cabinet key. The cabinet stayed locked between logged loans, and no key or sample changed hands. I had no access to the toxin. I had something to hide, but I did not murder Grant Larceny.

Murderer Coming Clean: Grant intended to make the Star Bowl a permanent Meridian holding. That would destroy months of restitution negotiations and humiliate the international partners I represent. He wanted an announcement before anybody could challenge his claim. I wanted him to stop. During setup I borrowed the cabinet key and took the toxin sample. At 6:44, I used the excuse of delivering the restitution memorandum to enter the salon. I dampened my gold-seamed linen with the sample and wiped the inside of Grant's coupe and its rim. That transferred the poison. I left with

the cloth. The door entry, key loan and linen receipt were all real. What I left out was what I did between them.

Innocent preparation record: MERIDIAN / PREPARATION RECORD Salon door register: 6:44. Conservation key book: no key loan. Materials inventory, 6:39: white linen cloth, gold seam. Purpose noted by guest: delivering the restitution memorandum; dusting the travel case for a loan object. These are the original preparation records for Mona Lott.

Murderer preparation record: MERIDIAN / PREPARATION RECORD Salon door register: 6:44. Conservation key book: loan at 6:13, returned and cabinet relocked. Materials inventory, 6:39: white linen cloth, gold seam. Purpose noted by guest: delivering the restitution memorandum; dusting the travel case for a loan object. These are the original preparation records for Mona Lott.

## **Elon Mosaic**

Victim relationship: Grant had blacklisted you from a major acquisition after you outbid him anonymously for a work he wanted. Tonight he planned to announce that your collecting practices were 'speculative theater' and block your appointment to the museum board.

Hidden complication: You were the anonymous buyer in the auction incident everyone keeps referencing. You concealed your identity through Hugh to avoid a bidding war with Grant.

Innocent route: I went into the Donor Salon at 6:48, discussing the board appointment. I borrowed the cabinet key during setup to inspect the reference mineral stored inside. I carried blue disposable paper wipes, for polishing my presentation case. That was what the materials desk issued me. You did not poison Grant.

Murderer route: During setup you borrowed the controlled cabinet key and took the toxin sample. At 6:48 you entered the Donor Salon, discussing the board appointment. You dampened your issued gold-seamed linen with the stolen sample and wiped the inside of Grant's coupe and its rim, transferring the toxin. You left with the cloth. You acted alone.

Innocent Coming Clean: I was the anonymous auction buyer. Hugh helped conceal my name so Grant would not start a bidding war. The materials desk issued me blue paper wipes, not gold-seamed linen. The poisoned smear contains the gold thread from a cloth; the paper I carried cannot have left it. I had something to hide, but I did not murder Grant Larceny.

Murderer Coming Clean: I outbid Grant anonymously for a work he wanted. He blacklisted me from another acquisition and planned to block my museum board appointment. Tonight he was going to call my collecting speculative theater. It was an expensive grudge, even by his standards. During setup I borrowed the cabinet key and took the toxin sample. At 6:48, I used the excuse of discussing the board appointment to enter the salon. I dampened my gold-seamed linen with the sample and wiped the inside of Grant's coupe and its rim. That transferred the poison. I left with the cloth. The door entry, key loan and linen receipt were all real. What I left out was what I did between them.

Innocent preparation record: MERIDIAN / PREPARATION RECORD Salon door register: 6:48. Conservation key book: loan at 6:14, returned and cabinet relocked. Materials inventory, 6:39: blue disposable paper wipes. Purpose noted by guest: discussing the board appointment; polishing my presentation case. These are the original preparation records for Elon Mosaic.

Murderer preparation record: MERIDIAN / PREPARATION RECORD Salon door register: 6:48. Conservation key book: loan at 6:14, returned and cabinet relocked. Materials inventory, 6:39: white linen cloth, gold seam. Purpose noted by guest: discussing the board appointment; polishing my presentation case. These are the original preparation records for Elon Mosaic.

## **Anya Tique**

Victim relationship: Grant planned to reveal that you accepted his first questionable donation in 1989 despite incomplete paperwork, staining the legacy you built.

Hidden complication: You did approve that accession because the museum was desperate for funds and you convinced yourself the paperwork would follow.

Innocent route: I went into the Donor Salon at 6:36, asking about the old donation file. I did not go back after that. I borrowed the cabinet key during setup to inspect the accession-display treatment card stored inside. I carried a white linen cloth with a gold seam, for dusting an old catalogue cover. That was what the materials desk issued me. You did not poison Grant.

Murderer route: During setup you borrowed the controlled cabinet key and took the toxin sample. At 6:45 you entered the Donor Salon on your printed errand. You dampened your gold-seamed linen with the sample and wiped the inside of Grant's coupe and its rim. You acted alone.

Innocent Coming Clean: I accepted the 1989 gift before its export papers arrived. I convinced myself the paperwork would follow. That failure should have been corrected years ago. My recorded salon visit ended before 6:40 and I did not return. The coupe was still clean at 6:40; I was not inside during the poisoning window. I had something to hide, but I did not murder Grant Larceny.

Murderer Coming Clean: In 1989 I accepted one of Grant's early donations with incomplete paperwork. He planned to expose that tonight and stain the museum legacy I built. I should have demanded the missing documents then. He was making sure everybody would hear that now. I decided he would not make it through his own gala. During setup I borrowed the conservation cabinet key, stole the toxin sample and returned the key so the cabinet could be relocked. At 6:45 I entered the Donor Salon using my ordinary errand as cover. I dampened my white, gold-seamed linen with the sample and wiped the inside of Grant's silver coupe and its rim. The glass was clean at 6:40; he drank at 6:49. The toxin went onto the glass, not into the decanter or food. The gold thread and wipe marks came from my cloth. The salon entry, key loan and linen inventory together trace exactly what I did. Nobody helped me.

Innocent preparation record: MERIDIAN / PREPARATION RECORD Salon door register: 6:36; no later entry. Conservation key book: loan at 6:15,

returned and cabinet relocked. Materials inventory, 6:39: white linen cloth, gold seam. Purpose noted by guest: asking about the old donation file; dusting an old catalogue cover. These are the original preparation records for Anya Tique.

Murderer preparation record: MERIDIAN / PREPARATION RECORD Salon door register: 6:45. Conservation key book: loan at 6:15, returned and cabinet relocked. Materials inventory, 6:39: white linen cloth, gold seam. Purpose noted by guest: asking about the old donation file; dusting an old catalogue cover. These are the original preparation records for Anya Tique.

## **Saul D. Bid**

Victim relationship: Grant threatened to expose a private sale you arranged outside your auction house's normal process unless you waived a substantial fee.

Hidden complication: You did route the sale through a discreet subsidiary to satisfy a client who insisted on anonymity.

Innocent route: I went into the Donor Salon at 6:45, discussing the auction fee. I visited the conservation display, checking a sale display sample, but did not borrow the cabinet key. I carried a white linen cloth with a gold seam, for polishing a catalogue stand. That was what the materials desk issued me. You did not poison Grant.

Murderer route: During setup you borrowed the controlled cabinet key and took the toxin sample. At 6:45 you entered the Donor Salon on your printed errand. You dampened your gold-seamed linen with the sample and wiped the inside of Grant's coupe and its rim. You acted alone.

Innocent Coming Clean: I routed that private sale through a subsidiary to protect a client's anonymity. I was hiding the transaction, not a murder. The key book confirms I never borrowed the cabinet key. The cabinet stayed locked between logged loans, and no key or sample changed hands. I had no access to the toxin. I had something to hide, but I did not murder Grant Larceny.

**Murderer Coming Clean:** I arranged a private sale outside my auction house's normal process. Grant threatened to expose it unless I waived a substantial fee. He wanted the convenience of discretion and the price of a favor. My career was his bargaining chip. I decided he would not make it through his own gala. During setup I borrowed the conservation cabinet key, stole the toxin sample and returned the key so the cabinet could be relocked. At 6:45 I entered the Donor Salon using my ordinary errand as cover. I dampened my white, gold-seamed linen with the sample and wiped the inside of Grant's silver coupe and its rim. The glass was clean at 6:40; he drank at 6:49. The toxin went onto the glass, not into the decanter or food. The gold thread and wipe marks came from my cloth. The salon entry, key loan and linen inventory together trace exactly what I did. Nobody helped me.

**Innocent preparation record:** MERIDIAN / PREPARATION RECORD Salon door register: 6:45. Conservation key book: no key loan. Materials inventory, 6:39: white linen cloth, gold seam. Purpose noted by guest: discussing the auction fee; polishing a catalogue stand. These are the original preparation records for Saul D. Bid.

**Murderer preparation record:** MERIDIAN / PREPARATION RECORD Salon door register: 6:45. Conservation key book: loan at 6:16, returned and cabinet relocked. Materials inventory, 6:39: white linen cloth, gold seam. Purpose noted by guest: discussing the auction fee; polishing a catalogue stand. These are the original preparation records for Saul D. Bid.

## **Elle Loominate**

**Victim relationship:** Grant intended to purchase a family-owned ceremonial textile you had borrowed for your installation, despite your refusal to sell.

**Hidden complication:** The textile is in the exhibition without the full paperwork your family expected because you were afraid the loan would be denied.

**Innocent route:** I went into the Donor Salon at 6:45, explaining the textile loan. I borrowed the cabinet key during setup to inspect the fabric-treatment sample stored inside. I carried blue disposable paper

wipes, for cleaning the textile display rail. That was what the materials desk issued me. You did not poison Grant.

Murderer route: During setup you borrowed the controlled cabinet key and took the toxin sample. At 6:45 you entered the Donor Salon on your printed errand. You dampened your gold-seamed linen with the sample and wiped the inside of Grant's coupe and its rim. You acted alone.

Innocent Coming Clean: I displayed my family's textile before the loan paperwork was complete. I feared losing its place in the exhibition. I had no right to rush that permission. The materials desk issued me blue paper wipes, not gold-seamed linen. The poisoned smear contains the gold thread from a cloth; the paper I carried cannot have left it. I had something to hide, but I did not murder Grant Larceny.

Murderer Coming Clean: The ceremonial textile belongs to a family who lent it for my installation. It is not mine to sell. Grant intended to purchase it despite my refusal. He treated a loan as a price negotiation and expected me to make the family accept it. I decided he would not make it through his own gala. During setup I borrowed the conservation cabinet key, stole the toxin sample and returned the key so the cabinet could be relocked. At 6:45 I entered the Donor Salon using my ordinary errand as cover. I dampened my white, gold-seamed linen with the sample and wiped the inside of Grant's silver coupe and its rim. The glass was clean at 6:40; he drank at 6:49. The toxin went onto the glass, not into the decanter or food. The gold thread and wipe marks came from my cloth. The salon entry, key loan and linen inventory together trace exactly what I did. Nobody helped me.

Innocent preparation record: MERIDIAN / PREPARATION RECORD Salon door register: 6:45. Conservation key book: loan at 6:17, returned and cabinet relocked. Materials inventory, 6:39: blue disposable paper wipes. Purpose noted by guest: explaining the textile loan; cleaning the textile display rail. These are the original preparation records for Elle Loominate.

Murderer preparation record: MERIDIAN / PREPARATION RECORD Salon door register: 6:45. Conservation key book: loan at 6:17, returned and cabinet relocked. Materials inventory, 6:39: white linen cloth, gold seam.

Purpose noted by guest: explaining the textile loan; cleaning the textile display rail. These are the original preparation records for Elle Loominate.

## **Reed DeLabel**

Victim relationship: You found an archival document that contradicted the Star Bowl label. Grant told your department your fellowship could disappear if you pushed it.

Hidden complication: You have not yet told Art that your discovery also undermines one sentence in his published research.

Innocent route: I went into the Donor Salon at 6:36, showing him the archival correction. I did not go back after that. I visited the conservation display, reading a conservation label, but did not borrow the cabinet key. I carried a white linen cloth with a gold seam, for dusting a label holder. That was what the materials desk issued me. You did not poison Grant.

Murderer route: During setup you borrowed the controlled cabinet key and took the toxin sample. At 6:45 you entered the Donor Salon on your printed errand. You dampened your gold-seamed linen with the sample and wiped the inside of Grant's coupe and its rim. You acted alone.

Innocent Coming Clean: My discovery also contradicts a sentence in Art's research. I delayed telling him because I did not want to lose my mentor. My recorded salon visit ended before 6:40 and I did not return. The coupe was still clean at 6:40; I was not inside during the poisoning window. I had something to hide, but I did not murder Grant Larceny.

Murderer Coming Clean: An archival document contradicted the Star Bowl label. I found it. Grant told my department my fellowship could disappear if I pushed the issue. I could lose the position I worked for simply by insisting that our label tell the truth. I decided he would not make it through his own gala. During setup I borrowed the conservation cabinet key, stole the toxin sample and returned the key so the cabinet could be relocked. At 6:45 I entered the Donor Salon using my ordinary errand as cover. I dampened my white, gold-seamed linen with the sample and wiped the inside of Grant's silver coupe and its rim. The glass was clean at 6:40; he drank at 6:49. The

toxin went onto the glass, not into the decanter or food. The gold thread and wipe marks came from my cloth. The salon entry, key loan and linen inventory together trace exactly what I did. Nobody helped me.

Innocent preparation record: MERIDIAN / PREPARATION RECORD Salon door register: 6:36; no later entry. Conservation key book: no key loan. Materials inventory, 6:39: white linen cloth, gold seam. Purpose noted by guest: showing him the archival correction; dusting a label holder. These are the original preparation records for Reed DeLabel.

Murderer preparation record: MERIDIAN / PREPARATION RECORD Salon door register: 6:45. Conservation key book: loan at 6:18, returned and cabinet relocked. Materials inventory, 6:39: white linen cloth, gold seam. Purpose noted by guest: showing him the archival correction; dusting a label holder. These are the original preparation records for Reed DeLabel.

## Al Baster

Victim relationship: Grant planned to replace your commissioned entrance sculpture with a cheaper replica after the opening and dispute your final payment.

Hidden complication: You built one internal support differently from the approved plan because the fabricator missed a deadline.

Innocent route: I went into the Donor Salon at 6:36, discussing the entrance sculpture. I did not go back after that. I borrowed the cabinet key during setup to inspect the resin sample stored inside. I carried blue disposable paper wipes, for wiping a sculpture support. That was what the materials desk issued me. You did not poison Grant.

Murderer route: During setup you borrowed the controlled cabinet key and took the toxin sample. At 6:45 you entered the Donor Salon on your printed errand. You dampened your gold-seamed linen with the sample and wiped the inside of Grant's coupe and its rim. You acted alone.

Innocent Coming Clean: I changed one internal support in my sculpture to meet a deadline. I was concealing a construction compromise. My recorded salon visit ended before 6:40 and I did not return. The coupe was still clean

at 6:40; I was not inside during the poisoning window. I had something to hide, but I did not murder Grant Larceny.

**Murderer Coming Clean:** Grant wanted to replace my commissioned entrance sculpture with a cheaper replica after opening night and dispute my final payment. He would still have the photographs of my work at his gala. I would have the invoice and an empty plinth. I decided he would not make it through his own gala. During setup I borrowed the conservation cabinet key, stole the toxin sample and returned the key so the cabinet could be relocked. At 6:45 I entered the Donor Salon using my ordinary errand as cover. I dampened my white, gold-seamed linen with the sample and wiped the inside of Grant's silver coupe and its rim. The glass was clean at 6:40; he drank at 6:49. The toxin went onto the glass, not into the decanter or food. The gold thread and wipe marks came from my cloth. The salon entry, key loan and linen inventory together trace exactly what I did. Nobody helped me.

**Innocent preparation record:** MERIDIAN / PREPARATION RECORD Salon door register: 6:36; no later entry. Conservation key book: loan at 6:19, returned and cabinet relocked. Materials inventory, 6:39: blue disposable paper wipes. Purpose noted by guest: discussing the entrance sculpture; wiping a sculpture support. These are the original preparation records for Al Baster.

**Murderer preparation record:** MERIDIAN / PREPARATION RECORD Salon door register: 6:45. Conservation key book: loan at 6:19, returned and cabinet relocked. Materials inventory, 6:39: white linen cloth, gold seam. Purpose noted by guest: discussing the entrance sculpture; wiping a sculpture support. These are the original preparation records for Al Baster.

## Ella Gance

**Victim relationship:** Grant knew you quietly sold a work you had publicly promised to donate to another institution and planned to expose the contradiction.

**Hidden complication:** You sold it to cover a failed business investment and hoped to replace it before anyone noticed.

Innocent route: I went into the Donor Salon at 6:36, discussing the promised donation. I did not go back after that. I borrowed the cabinet key during setup to inspect the display-finish sample stored inside. I carried a white linen cloth with a gold seam, for drying a splash from my auction catalogue. That was what the materials desk issued me. You did not poison Grant.

Murderer route: During setup you borrowed the controlled cabinet key and took the toxin sample. At 6:45 you entered the Donor Salon on your printed errand. You dampened your gold-seamed linen with the sample and wiped the inside of Grant's coupe and its rim. You acted alone.

Innocent Coming Clean: I sold the work I had promised to donate. A failed investment left me desperate for cash, and I hoped to replace it before anyone noticed. My recorded salon visit ended before 6:40 and I did not return. The coupe was still clean at 6:40; I was not inside during the poisoning window. I had something to hide, but I did not murder Grant Larceny.

Murderer Coming Clean: I sold a work I had publicly promised to donate to another institution. Grant knew and planned to expose the contradiction tonight. It was an ugly position, and he was preparing to turn my embarrassment into entertainment for the entire room. I decided he would not make it through his own gala. During setup I borrowed the conservation cabinet key, stole the toxin sample and returned the key so the cabinet could be relocked. At 6:45 I entered the Donor Salon using my ordinary errand as cover. I dampened my white, gold-seamed linen with the sample and wiped the inside of Grant's silver coupe and its rim. The glass was clean at 6:40; he drank at 6:49. The toxin went onto the glass, not into the decanter or food. The gold thread and wipe marks came from my cloth. The salon entry, key loan and linen inventory together trace exactly what I did. Nobody helped me.

Innocent preparation record: MERIDIAN / PREPARATION RECORD Salon door register: 6:36; no later entry. Conservation key book: loan at 6:20, returned and cabinet relocked. Materials inventory, 6:39: white linen cloth, gold seam. Purpose noted by guest: discussing the promised donation;

drying a splash from my auction catalogue. These are the original preparation records for Ella Gance.

Murderer preparation record: MERIDIAN / PREPARATION RECORD Salon door register: 6:45. Conservation key book: loan at 6:20, returned and cabinet relocked. Materials inventory, 6:39: white linen cloth, gold seam. Purpose noted by guest: discussing the promised donation; drying a splash from my auction catalogue. These are the original preparation records for Ella Gance.

## **Drew Conclusions**

Victim relationship: Grant discovered that you write an anonymous satirical newsletter skewering museum patrons and planned to unmask you during his speech.

Hidden complication: Several jokes in the newsletter came from private conversations, and you regret at least one of them.

Innocent route: I went into the Donor Salon at 6:45, asking about his speech. I visited the conservation display, checking a display for my newsletter, but did not borrow the cabinet key. I carried a white linen cloth with a gold seam, for cleaning a smudge from my recording case. That was what the materials desk issued me. You did not poison Grant.

Murderer route: During setup you borrowed the controlled cabinet key and took the toxin sample. At 6:45 you entered the Donor Salon on your printed errand. You dampened your gold-seamed linen with the sample and wiped the inside of Grant's coupe and its rim. You acted alone.

Innocent Coming Clean: I wrote jokes using private conversations. I regret hurting people who trusted me. The newsletter was my secret. The key book confirms I never borrowed the cabinet key. The cabinet stayed locked between logged loans, and no key or sample changed hands. I had no access to the toxin. I had something to hide, but I did not murder Grant Larceny.

Murderer Coming Clean: I write the anonymous newsletter that makes fun of museum patrons. Grant found out and planned to unmask me in his speech. Those patrons commission my other work. Losing anonymity could

cost me rather more than a polite laugh. I decided he would not make it through his own gala. During setup I borrowed the conservation cabinet key, stole the toxin sample and returned the key so the cabinet could be relocked. At 6:45 I entered the Donor Salon using my ordinary errand as cover. I dampened my white, gold-seamed linen with the sample and wiped the inside of Grant's silver coupe and its rim. The glass was clean at 6:40; he drank at 6:49. The toxin went onto the glass, not into the decanter or food. The gold thread and wipe marks came from my cloth. The salon entry, key loan and linen inventory together trace exactly what I did. Nobody helped me.

Innocent preparation record: MERIDIAN / PREPARATION RECORD Salon door register: 6:45. Conservation key book: no key loan. Materials inventory, 6:39: white linen cloth, gold seam. Purpose noted by guest: asking about his speech; cleaning a smudge from my recording case. These are the original preparation records for Drew Conclusions.

Murderer preparation record: MERIDIAN / PREPARATION RECORD Salon door register: 6:45. Conservation key book: loan at 6:21, returned and cabinet relocked. Materials inventory, 6:39: white linen cloth, gold seam. Purpose noted by guest: asking about his speech; cleaning a smudge from my recording case. These are the original preparation records for Drew Conclusions.

## **Brie DeVivre**

Victim relationship: Grant had refused to approve the final catering invoice and planned to blame you for a last-minute service change he personally ordered.

Hidden complication: You changed his private beverage setup twice because Grant and his assistant gave contradictory instructions.

Innocent route: I went into the Donor Salon at 6:45, confirming the private menu. I borrowed the cabinet key during setup to inspect the tray-cleaning notice stored inside. I carried blue disposable paper wipes, for drying a serving tray. That was what the materials desk issued me. You did not poison Grant.

**Murderer route:** During setup you borrowed the controlled cabinet key and took the toxin sample. At 6:45 you entered the Donor Salon on your printed errand. You dampened your gold-seamed linen with the sample and wiped the inside of Grant's coupe and its rim. You acted alone.

**Innocent Coming Clean:** I changed the private drink setup twice because Grant and his assistant gave opposite orders. That confusion was real; poisoning the drink was not my work. The materials desk issued me blue paper wipes, not gold-seamed linen. The poisoned smear contains the gold thread from a cloth; the paper I carried cannot have left it. I had something to hide, but I did not murder Grant Larceny.

**Murderer Coming Clean:** Grant personally ordered a last-minute service change, refused to approve the final catering invoice, then planned to blame the change on me. He had eaten very well. He simply did not want to pay for it or admit it was his idea. I decided he would not make it through his own gala. During setup I borrowed the conservation cabinet key, stole the toxin sample and returned the key so the cabinet could be relocked. At 6:45 I entered the Donor Salon using my ordinary errand as cover. I dampened my white, gold-seamed linen with the sample and wiped the inside of Grant's silver coupe and its rim. The glass was clean at 6:40; he drank at 6:49. The toxin went onto the glass, not into the decanter or food. The gold thread and wipe marks came from my cloth. The salon entry, key loan and linen inventory together trace exactly what I did. Nobody helped me.

**Innocent preparation record:** MERIDIAN / PREPARATION RECORD Salon door register: 6:45. Conservation key book: loan at 6:22, returned and cabinet relocked. Materials inventory, 6:39: blue disposable paper wipes. Purpose noted by guest: confirming the private menu; drying a serving tray. These are the original preparation records for Brie DeVivre.

**Murderer preparation record:** MERIDIAN / PREPARATION RECORD Salon door register: 6:45. Conservation key book: loan at 6:22, returned and cabinet relocked. Materials inventory, 6:39: white linen cloth, gold seam. Purpose noted by guest: confirming the private menu; drying a serving tray. These are the original preparation records for Brie DeVivre.

## Cary Crates

**Victim relationship:** Grant saw you damage a minor frame during installation and threatened to have you fired after the gala, despite the damage being repairable.

**Hidden complication:** You concealed the crack with a reversible mount until Chip could inspect it after opening night.

**Innocent route:** I went into the Donor Salon at 6:36, explaining the damaged frame. I did not go back after that. I visited the conservation display, checking a frame-treatment sample, but did not borrow the cabinet key. I carried a white linen cloth with a gold seam, for cleaning a crate handle. That was what the materials desk issued me. You did not poison Grant.

**Murderer route:** During setup you borrowed the controlled cabinet key and took the toxin sample. At 6:45 you entered the Donor Salon on your printed errand. You dampened your gold-seamed linen with the sample and wiped the inside of Grant's coupe and its rim. You acted alone.

**Innocent Coming Clean:** I concealed a cracked frame with a reversible mount until Chip could inspect it. I was trying to keep the gala moving and should have reported it immediately. My recorded salon visit ended before 6:40 and I did not return. The coupe was still clean at 6:40; I was not inside during the poisoning window. I had something to hide, but I did not murder Grant Larceny.

**Murderer Coming Clean:** I damaged a minor frame during installation. It could be repaired, but Grant threatened to have me fired after the gala. I was ready to put it right. He seemed much more interested in demonstrating that he could end my job. I decided he would not make it through his own gala. During setup I borrowed the conservation cabinet key, stole the toxin sample and returned the key so the cabinet could be relocked. At 6:45 I entered the Donor Salon using my ordinary errand as cover. I dampened my white, gold-seamed linen with the sample and wiped the inside of Grant's silver coupe and its rim. The glass was clean at 6:40; he drank at 6:49. The toxin went onto the glass, not into the decanter or food. The gold thread and

wipe marks came from my cloth. The salon entry, key loan and linen inventory together trace exactly what I did. Nobody helped me.

Innocent preparation record: MERIDIAN / PREPARATION RECORD Salon door register: 6:36; no later entry. Conservation key book: no key loan. Materials inventory, 6:39: white linen cloth, gold seam. Purpose noted by guest: explaining the damaged frame; cleaning a crate handle. These are the original preparation records for Cary Crates.

Murderer preparation record: MERIDIAN / PREPARATION RECORD Salon door register: 6:45. Conservation key book: loan at 6:23, returned and cabinet relocked. Materials inventory, 6:39: white linen cloth, gold seam. Purpose noted by guest: explaining the damaged frame; cleaning a crate handle. These are the original preparation records for Cary Crates.

## **Anne E. Dote**

Victim relationship: Grant's gift conditions would cut public education programming to fund a private donor lounge and VIP entrance.

Hidden complication: You organized an anonymous staff petition against the plan and slipped copies into trustee folders.

Innocent route: I went into the Donor Salon at 6:36, discussing the education budget. I did not go back after that. I borrowed the cabinet key during setup to inspect the school-tour safety sheet stored inside. I carried blue disposable paper wipes, for dusting a school-tour display. That was what the materials desk issued me. You did not poison Grant.

Murderer route: During setup you borrowed the controlled cabinet key and took the toxin sample. At 6:45 you entered the Donor Salon on your printed errand. You dampened your gold-seamed linen with the sample and wiped the inside of Grant's coupe and its rim. You acted alone.

Innocent Coming Clean: I organized the anonymous petition against cuts to school programs. Those pages in the trustee folders came from me. My recorded salon visit ended before 6:40 and I did not return. The coupe was still clean at 6:40; I was not inside during the poisoning window. I had something to hide, but I did not murder Grant Larceny.

**Murderer Coming Clean:** Grant's gift conditions would cut school tours and community education to pay for a private donor lounge and VIP entrance. The children would get less museum so his friends could get more privacy. I wanted those conditions taken out. I decided he would not make it through his own gala. During setup I borrowed the conservation cabinet key, stole the toxin sample and returned the key so the cabinet could be relocked. At 6:45 I entered the Donor Salon using my ordinary errand as cover. I dampened my white, gold-seamed linen with the sample and wiped the inside of Grant's silver coupe and its rim. The glass was clean at 6:40; he drank at 6:49. The toxin went onto the glass, not into the decanter or food. The gold thread and wipe marks came from my cloth. The salon entry, key loan and linen inventory together trace exactly what I did. Nobody helped me.

**Innocent preparation record:** MERIDIAN / PREPARATION RECORD Salon door register: 6:36; no later entry. Conservation key book: loan at 6:24, returned and cabinet relocked. Materials inventory, 6:39: blue disposable paper wipes. Purpose noted by guest: discussing the education budget; dusting a school-tour display. These are the original preparation records for Anne E. Dote.

**Murderer preparation record:** MERIDIAN / PREPARATION RECORD Salon door register: 6:45. Conservation key book: loan at 6:24, returned and cabinet relocked. Materials inventory, 6:39: white linen cloth, gold seam. Purpose noted by guest: discussing the education budget; dusting a school-tour display. These are the original preparation records for Anne E. Dote.

## **Faye Stop**

**Victim relationship:** Grant ordered you to surrender a photograph showing him meeting privately with Hugh beside a shell-company shipping file.

**Hidden complication:** You kept a backup print after agreeing to delete the image from your camera.

**Innocent route:** I went into the Donor Salon at 6:36, asking him about my photograph. I did not go back after that. I borrowed the cabinet key during

setup to inspect the display-cleaning sample stored inside. I carried a white linen cloth with a gold seam, for cleaning the outside of my camera case. That was what the materials desk issued me. You did not poison Grant.

Murderer route: During setup you borrowed the controlled cabinet key and took the toxin sample. At 6:45 you entered the Donor Salon on your printed errand. You dampened your gold-seamed linen with the sample and wiped the inside of Grant's coupe and its rim. You acted alone.

Innocent Coming Clean: I kept a backup of the photograph Grant ordered me to delete. I wanted a record of what happened, not a donor's permission to erase it. My recorded salon visit ended before 6:40 and I did not return. The coupe was still clean at 6:40; I was not inside during the poisoning window. I had something to hide, but I did not murder Grant Larceny.

Murderer Coming Clean: I photographed Grant meeting Hugh beside a shell-company shipping file. Grant ordered me to surrender the photograph. I agreed to delete it from my camera, but kept a backup print. I was not comfortable letting him decide which pictures could exist. I decided he would not make it through his own gala. During setup I borrowed the conservation cabinet key, stole the toxin sample and returned the key so the cabinet could be relocked. At 6:45 I entered the Donor Salon using my ordinary errand as cover. I dampened my white, gold-seamed linen with the sample and wiped the inside of Grant's silver coupe and its rim. The glass was clean at 6:40; he drank at 6:49. The toxin went onto the glass, not into the decanter or food. The gold thread and wipe marks came from my cloth. The salon entry, key loan and linen inventory together trace exactly what I did. Nobody helped me.

Innocent preparation record: MERIDIAN / PREPARATION RECORD Salon door register: 6:36; no later entry. Conservation key book: loan at 6:25, returned and cabinet relocked. Materials inventory, 6:39: white linen cloth, gold seam. Purpose noted by guest: asking him about my photograph; cleaning the outside of my camera case. These are the original preparation records for Faye Stop.

Murderer preparation record: MERIDIAN / PREPARATION RECORD Salon door register: 6:45. Conservation key book: loan at 6:25, returned and

cabinet relocked. Materials inventory, 6:39: white linen cloth, gold seam. Purpose noted by guest: asking him about my photograph; cleaning the outside of my camera case. These are the original preparation records for Faye Stop.

## **Robin Banks**

Victim relationship: Grant had you removed from a previous museum event and threatened legal action if you disrupted tonight's unveiling.

Hidden complication: You planted small 'PROVENANCE IS A VERB' stickers in several gallery brochures for a peaceful protest.

Innocent route: I went into the Donor Salon at 6:45, delivering my protest letter. I visited the conservation display, reading the environmental warning, but did not borrow the cabinet key. I carried a white linen cloth with a gold seam, for wiping paste from a protest placard. That was what the materials desk issued me. You did not poison Grant.

Murderer route: During setup you borrowed the controlled cabinet key and took the toxin sample. At 6:45 you entered the Donor Salon on your printed errand. You dampened your gold-seamed linen with the sample and wiped the inside of Grant's coupe and its rim. You acted alone.

Innocent Coming Clean: I put the protest stickers in gallery brochures. I wanted people asking where the objects came from. It was a peaceful protest. The key book confirms I never borrowed the cabinet key. The cabinet stayed locked between logged loans, and no key or sample changed hands. I had no access to the toxin. I had something to hide, but I did not murder Grant Larceny.

Murderer Coming Clean: Grant had me removed from a previous museum event. He threatened legal action if I disrupted this unveiling. My protest concerns restitution, not his comfort. He wanted silence tonight, and I was not ready to promise him that. I decided he would not make it through his own gala. During setup I borrowed the conservation cabinet key, stole the toxin sample and returned the key so the cabinet could be relocked. At 6:45 I entered the Donor Salon using my ordinary errand as cover. I dampened my

white, gold-seamed linen with the sample and wiped the inside of Grant's silver coupe and its rim. The glass was clean at 6:40; he drank at 6:49. The toxin went onto the glass, not into the decanter or food. The gold thread and wipe marks came from my cloth. The salon entry, key loan and linen inventory together trace exactly what I did. Nobody helped me.

Innocent preparation record: MERIDIAN / PREPARATION RECORD Salon door register: 6:45. Conservation key book: no key loan. Materials inventory, 6:39: white linen cloth, gold seam. Purpose noted by guest: delivering my protest letter; wiping paste from a protest placard. These are the original preparation records for Robin Banks.

Murderer preparation record: MERIDIAN / PREPARATION RECORD Salon door register: 6:45. Conservation key book: loan at 6:26, returned and cabinet relocked. Materials inventory, 6:39: white linen cloth, gold seam. Purpose noted by guest: delivering my protest letter; wiping paste from a protest placard. These are the original preparation records for Robin Banks.

## **Penny Pincher**

Victim relationship: One decorative object in the exhibition once belonged to your family. You believe Grant acquired it through a manipulative private sale decades ago.

Hidden complication: You brought old correspondence proving your family contested that sale and planned to confront him tonight.

Innocent route: I went into the Donor Salon at 6:45, asking about the family object. I borrowed the cabinet key during setup to inspect the object-treatment label stored inside. I carried blue disposable paper wipes, for dusting the family-object display. That was what the materials desk issued me. You did not poison Grant.

Murderer route: During setup you borrowed the controlled cabinet key and took the toxin sample. At 6:45 you entered the Donor Salon on your printed errand. You dampened your gold-seamed linen with the sample and wiped the inside of Grant's coupe and its rim. You acted alone.

Innocent Coming Clean: I brought the old letters disputing my family's sale. I meant to confront Grant in front of witnesses, not silence him forever. The materials desk issued me blue paper wipes, not gold-seamed linen. The poisoned smear contains the gold thread from a cloth; the paper I carried cannot have left it. I had something to hide, but I did not murder Grant Larceny.

Murderer Coming Clean: An object here once belonged to my family. I believe Grant acquired it through a manipulative private sale decades ago. Seeing it celebrated as his generosity is difficult. I want the history acknowledged and the ownership questioned. I decided he would not make it through his own gala. During setup I borrowed the conservation cabinet key, stole the toxin sample and returned the key so the cabinet could be relocked. At 6:45 I entered the Donor Salon using my ordinary errand as cover. I dampened my white, gold-seamed linen with the sample and wiped the inside of Grant's silver coupe and its rim. The glass was clean at 6:40; he drank at 6:49. The toxin went onto the glass, not into the decanter or food. The gold thread and wipe marks came from my cloth. The salon entry, key loan and linen inventory together trace exactly what I did. Nobody helped me.

Innocent preparation record: MERIDIAN / PREPARATION RECORD Salon door register: 6:45. Conservation key book: loan at 6:27, returned and cabinet relocked. Materials inventory, 6:39: blue disposable paper wipes. Purpose noted by guest: asking about the family object; dusting the family-object display. These are the original preparation records for Penny Pincher.

Murderer preparation record: MERIDIAN / PREPARATION RECORD Salon door register: 6:45. Conservation key book: loan at 6:27, returned and cabinet relocked. Materials inventory, 6:39: white linen cloth, gold seam. Purpose noted by guest: asking about the family object; dusting the family-object display. These are the original preparation records for Penny Pincher.

## Justin Tyme

Victim relationship: Grant fed you several flattering claims for an earlier profile that you later discovered were exaggerated. He threatened to cut off access if you corrected them.

Hidden complication: You are preparing a correction that will also make you look embarrassingly credulous.

Innocent route: I went into the Donor Salon at 6:36, asking about the disputed profile. I did not go back after that. I visited the conservation display, checking an accession display, but did not borrow the cabinet key. I carried a white linen cloth with a gold seam, for cleaning a notebook cover. That was what the materials desk issued me. You did not poison Grant.

Murderer route: During setup you borrowed the controlled cabinet key and took the toxin sample. At 6:45 you entered the Donor Salon on your printed errand. You dampened your gold-seamed linen with the sample and wiped the inside of Grant's coupe and its rim. You acted alone.

Innocent Coming Clean: I was preparing a correction to my flattering profile of Grant. Admitting I had been credulous would hurt, but readers deserved the correction. My recorded salon visit ended before 6:40 and I did not return. The coupe was still clean at 6:40; I was not inside during the poisoning window. I had something to hide, but I did not murder Grant Larceny.

Murderer Coming Clean: Grant supplied flattering claims for my earlier profile that I later found were exaggerated. He threatened to cut off access if I corrected them. I would either lose an important source or leave my name on reporting I no longer trusted. I decided he would not make it through his own gala. During setup I borrowed the conservation cabinet key, stole the toxin sample and returned the key so the cabinet could be relocked. At 6:45 I entered the Donor Salon using my ordinary errand as cover. I dampened my white, gold-seamed linen with the sample and wiped the inside of Grant's silver coupe and its rim. The glass was clean at 6:40; he drank at 6:49. The toxin went onto the glass, not into the decanter or food. The gold thread and

wipe marks came from my cloth. The salon entry, key loan and linen inventory together trace exactly what I did. Nobody helped me.

Innocent preparation record: MERIDIAN / PREPARATION RECORD Salon door register: 6:36; no later entry. Conservation key book: no key loan. Materials inventory, 6:39: white linen cloth, gold seam. Purpose noted by guest: asking about the disputed profile; cleaning a notebook cover. These are the original preparation records for Justin Tyme.

Murderer preparation record: MERIDIAN / PREPARATION RECORD Salon door register: 6:45. Conservation key book: loan at 6:28, returned and cabinet relocked. Materials inventory, 6:39: white linen cloth, gold seam. Purpose noted by guest: asking about the disputed profile; cleaning a notebook cover. These are the original preparation records for Justin Tyme.

## Minnie Malist

Victim relationship: Grant ordered you to add a gaudy lighting cue to the unveiling and threatened to withhold payment when Frank objected.

Hidden complication: You secretly changed the cue again after approval, causing the eerie light flickers guests noticed during Act I.

Innocent route: I went into the Donor Salon at 6:36, checking his new lighting cue. I did not go back after that. I borrowed the cabinet key during setup to inspect the display cable fitting stored inside. I carried blue disposable paper wipes, for wiping a lighting controller. That was what the materials desk issued me. You did not poison Grant.

Murderer route: During setup you borrowed the controlled cabinet key and took the toxin sample. At 6:45 you entered the Donor Salon on your printed errand. You dampened your gold-seamed linen with the sample and wiped the inside of Grant's coupe and its rim. You acted alone.

Innocent Coming Clean: I changed the lighting cue after approval. The flicker was my unauthorized experiment. It had no supernatural cause and nothing to do with the poison. My recorded salon visit ended before 6:40 and I did not return. The coupe was still clean at 6:40; I was not inside

during the poisoning window. I had something to hide, but I did not murder Grant Larceny.

**Murderer Coming Clean:** Grant ordered a gaudy lighting cue for the unveiling. Frank objected, and Grant threatened to withhold my payment. I was caught between the person designing the display and the person holding the money. Neither planned to share the blame. I decided he would not make it through his own gala. During setup I borrowed the conservation cabinet key, stole the toxin sample and returned the key so the cabinet could be relocked. At 6:45 I entered the Donor Salon using my ordinary errand as cover. I dampened my white, gold-seamed linen with the sample and wiped the inside of Grant's silver coupe and its rim. The glass was clean at 6:40; he drank at 6:49. The toxin went onto the glass, not into the decanter or food. The gold thread and wipe marks came from my cloth. The salon entry, key loan and linen inventory together trace exactly what I did. Nobody helped me.

**Innocent preparation record:** MERIDIAN / PREPARATION RECORD Salon door register: 6:36; no later entry. Conservation key book: loan at 6:29, returned and cabinet relocked. Materials inventory, 6:39: blue disposable paper wipes. Purpose noted by guest: checking his new lighting cue; wiping a lighting controller. These are the original preparation records for Minnie Malist.

**Murderer preparation record:** MERIDIAN / PREPARATION RECORD Salon door register: 6:45. Conservation key book: loan at 6:29, returned and cabinet relocked. Materials inventory, 6:39: white linen cloth, gold seam. Purpose noted by guest: checking his new lighting cue; wiping a lighting controller. These are the original preparation records for Minnie Malist.